Lab 01: Mark-Making Studio

Level: Foundation Suggested time: 45 minutes Platform: Complete the core brief in either Procreate or Sketchbook Studio; use the comparison notes to transfer the workflow. Alignment: K1 | K2 | LO1

Scenario

A community arts centre needs a welcoming visual vocabulary for beginner workshop cards.

Your role: Junior digital illustrator Required deliverable: A labelled mark sheet with twelve pressure, speed and opacity variations.

Learning goal

Apply Canvas setup | stylus control | brush size | opacity | undo/redo to a real design decision and produce evidence that meets explicit acceptance criteria.

Before you begin

- Use an iPad that supports your chosen app and a compatible stylus where available.
- Save an editable, layered master before exporting a flattened image.
- Use only owned, licensed or clearly permitted reference images and record their sources.
- Create a folder named Lab-01-<YourName> for working files and evidence.

Part A - Plan and construct

1. Confirm the brief: the mark sheet must feel welcoming, exploratory and legible at tablet-screen size.
2. Create a working canvas at 2400 × 1600 px, RGB, and name it L01-Mark-Making-<YourName>.
3. Divide the canvas into twelve equal specimen zones with generous white space.
4. Warm up away from the final canvas: draw ten long lines, ten curves, ten pressure tapers and ten opacity fades.
5. Select four contrasting brush families and plan three controlled variations for each.
6. Keep one notes layer recording brush name, size, opacity and intended emotional quality.
7. Export the layered working file and a PNG; inspect the PNG at 25%, 50% and 100% zoom.

Part B - Procreate pathway

1. From Gallery, create the custom canvas; verify pixel dimensions in Canvas Information.
2. Open Brush Library and choose one brush each from Sketching, Inking, Painting and Airbrushing.
3. Use the left sliders to vary brush size and opacity; test Apple Pencil pressure and tilt where supported.
4. Use two-finger tap to undo and three-finger tap to redo while keeping intentional marks.
5. Create one named layer per brush family; tap N to confirm Normal blend and control layer opacity.
6. Use the colour disc/value panel to keep all specimens at the same value.
7. Export PNG from Actions → Share and retain the .procreate master.

Part C - Sketchbook Studio pathway

1. Create a blank page and verify the page orientation matches the specimen-board plan.

2. Test pen, pencil, marker, crayon, fountain, monoline and watercolour brushes.
3. Adjust brush size, colour and opacity; vary Apple Pencil pressure while keeping the same selected colour.
4. Use separate layers for each brush family; rename where the current build permits or keep a layer key in the guide.
5. Use Undo/Redo to recover accidental strokes without erasing useful variants.
6. Use the precise eraser to clean only the specimen-zone boundary.
7. Save the sketch on-device and export a PNG proof.

Evidence and acceptance checklist

[ ] 12 visibly different marks

[ ] At least three pressure responses

[ ] Readable grouping at fit-to-screen

[ ] Layered working file plus PNG

[ ] Layered working file is saved and opens correctly.

[ ] Final export uses a clear filename and matches the intended dimensions.

[ ] At least one in-progress screenshot shows the technique in use.

[ ] Reference sources and design decisions are recorded.

Peer review questions

1. Which marks feel calm, energetic or premium?
2. How did pressure and speed change the implied material?
3. Which app made the intended marks easiest to repeat?

Debrief

Use the Observe → Interpret → Connect → Propose pattern:

1. Observe: State what is visible without praise or blame.
2. Interpret: Explain the likely effect on attention, meaning, emotion or use.
3. Connect: Link the effect to the brief, a design principle or the acceptance criteria.
4. Propose: Name one specific change and how you will check whether it works.

Record one decision you will keep, one change you will test, and one technique you can transfer to the other app.

Troubleshooting

- The line feels wobbly: Zoom out, slow the decision rather than the stroke, use shoulder movement, and increase stabilisation only enough to preserve intent.
- Colour leaks during fill: Close the contour, inspect gaps at 100%, or place colour on a separate layer and clean with the precise eraser.
- The file becomes hard to edit: Name or document layer roles, hide unused experiments, group related stages and duplicate before merging or filtering.
- The image looks muddy: Check value grouping, lower overlay opacity, remove competing texture and restore one clear focal contrast.

- Perspective feels wrong: Return to horizon and vanishing logic; correct the large box before windows, props or decoration.

Submission package

Submit Lab-01-<YourName>/ containing:

- layered working file (or the app's saved layered sketch);
- final PNG/JPEG/PDF as required by the brief;
- progress evidence/contact sheet;
- short design rationale answering the peer-review questions; and
- reference/provenance list.

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